

Counterfactuals and Contentment

Bronze medalists tend to be happier than silver medalists. The most compelling counterfactual for the silver medalist is winning the gold. For the bronze medalist, the alternative is finishing without a medal at all.

Support for this interpretation was obtained from the 1992 Olympics and the 1994 Empire State Games. Athletes were rated at the conclusion of their events and on the medal stand.

The discussion focuses on the implications of endowment and contrast for well being. Objective achievements often matter less than how those achievements are framed.

A Second Section on Framing

Participants were randomly assigned to one of three experimental conditions. The correlation was statistically significant but modest in magnitude.

These results complicate the standard interpretation of the phenomenon. Robustness checks appear in the supplementary appendix.

We estimate the treatment effect using a difference in differences design. The sample skews younger and more educated than the general population.